argument was sound? Even if it was theoretically plausible, in practice the Americans failed to establish a stable democracy in Iraq. Does that mean that their attempt was wrong in the first place?

Just as deontologists trying to answer the question of identity are pushed to adopt utilitarian ideas, so utilitarians stymied by the lack of a suffering calculus often end up adopting a deontologist position. They uphold general rules like ‘Avoid wars of aggression’ or ‘Protect human rights’ even though they cannot show that following these rules always reduces the sum total of suffering in the world. History provides them only with a vague impression that following these rules tends to reduce suffering. And when some of these general rules clash – for example, when contemplating launching a war of aggression in order to protect human rights – utilitarianism doesn’t offer much practical help. Not even the most powerful computer network can perform the necessary calculations.

Accordingly, while utilitarianism promises a rational – and even mathematical – way to align every action with ‘the ultimate good’, in practice it may well produce just another mythology. Communist true believers confronted by the horrors of Stalinism often replied that the happiness that future generations would experience under ‘real socialism’ would redeem any short-term misery in the gulags. Libertarians, when asked about the immediate social harms of unrestricted free speech or the total abolition of taxes, express a similar faith that future benefits will outweigh any short-term damage. The danger of utilitarianism is that if you have a strong enough belief in a future utopia, it can become an open licence to inflict terrible suffering in the present. Indeed, this is a trick traditional religions discovered thousands of years ago. The crimes of this world could too easily be excused by the promises of future salvation.

COMPUTER MYTHOLOGY

How then did bureaucratic systems throughout history set their ultimate goals? They relied on mythology to do it for them. No matter how rational the officials, engineers, tax collectors and accountants were, they were ultimately in the service of this or that mythmaker. To paraphrase John Maynard Keynes, practical people who believe themselves to be quite exempt from any religious influence are usually the slaves of some